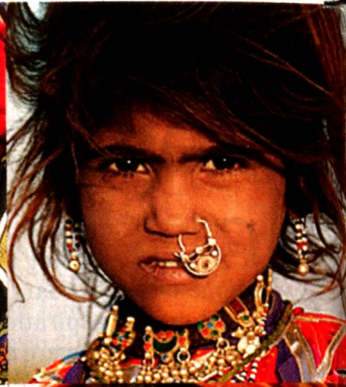
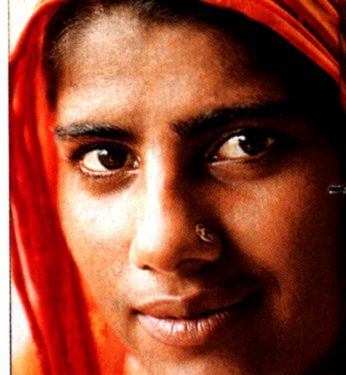




THE GREAT



INDIAN

By Raj Chengappa

Who were the first Indians? Were they the chocolate-hued Dravidian southerners or the dark-skinned tribals that inhabit East India and the Andaman islands? Was the relatively fair Indo-European population of the North the original settler? Or did the Mongoloid-featured Tibetan-Burmans beat the rest to it? When and how did the pioneers reach India? What routes did they take?

The answers to these questions have always been the subject of contentious debate and till recently well nigh impossible to conclude. After all today there are more than a billion Indians consisting of 4,693 communities, 4,500 endogamous groups, 325 functioning languages and 25 scripts. Not to mention the four main castes and the hundreds of sub-castes that throw up even more controversial questions such as: Are the Brahmins from a different genetic pool than that of the Shudras?

Now an unprecedented surge in genetic research across the country is overturning long-held theories and coming out with some fascinating

